who lived in the second century CE , and the Yogacara school of Buddhism taught at Nalanda. The name Huayan is derived from the Avatamsaka Sutra (Flower Garland Sutra), and this was transmitted to Japan to become well known as the Kegon school.

It is the Chan school which gained the most influence, particularly in its elaboration into the distinctively Japanese doctrine and meditation practice known as Zen. Zen is the Japanese rendering of Chan, which itself is derived from the Sanskrit word ‘dhyana’. Dhyana, or contemplation, in yogic terms, is regarded as the ‘journey of the mind’, ‘dhi’ being the mind and ‘yana’ denoting movement. This practice of contemplation takes the experience of the enlightenment of Lord Buddha as its central narrative. Zen understands itself as part of the tradition that is rooted in this great experience. But the practice of dhyana associated with Buddhism is rooted in the much older yogic tradition which was codified by Patanjali in his Yoga Shastra, composed sometime around the second or first century BCE . Its key elements include asana, or sitting in particular postures, pranayama, or modes of breathing, and dharana, or fixing the mind to an idea before achieving samadhi or an abiding stillness of the mind. These elements were adopted by Buddhism, though they are articulated in a different idiom. It is these ideas and practices which the Indian sage Bodhidharma took to China in the sixth century, and where he became celebrated as the first patriarch in China of the Chan school.

Little is known about Bodhidharma in India itself, but Chinese sources say that he was the third son of a Tamil Pallava king in Kanchipuram. He sailed to China to propagate Buddhism at the instance of his teacher Prajnatara. He settled down at a monastery in Shaolin, where he sat in deep meditation for thirteen years in front of a wall. At the end of that period, he is said to have lost the use of his limbs. That is how he is depicted in Japan – without hands and feet. In China, Bodhidharma is known as Damo and in Japan as Daruma.

In its travels through China, the idea of dhyana blended well with the already well-established doctrine of ‘Tao’, or ‘The Way’, associated with the philosopher Zhuang Zi. This, too, taught the value of contemplation, the